Dark Link

Shadow · the hero's own Fighter levels (Battle Master 20 on the ladder) · the room without walls in the Water Temple, *Ocarina of Time* · a sword, a shield, and nothing anyone has ever said about where it came from

Built on the 2024 rules, canon-first, from very little canon. This is the shadow of the Hero of Time, the one already on the ladder, so the source is one room of *Ocarina of Time* (1998): a shallow lake with no far shore, a dead tree on an island, and a black figure under it that wakes when the hero comes near. The game's whole text about it is Navi's: its name, and "Conquer yourself!" *Hyrule Historia* adds nothing about this one. No source says who made it, or whether anyone did. What the game does give is the fight, and the fight is exact: how much health it has, what each of the hero's weapons does to it, and what it does in answer to each of his moves. Those are read here from the fight's own logic, the game's decompiled code.

Design calls. It has no sheet of its own, and that is the first feat: its health is two points for every heart the hero has, so it's as strong as whoever walks in. The sheet is therefore a rule, **the Reflection**: take the hero's sheet at his level, keep his body and his sword arm, and strip what a shadow can't copy. At the Water Temple that's a ninth-level Fighter; on the ladder it's the shadow of the level-20 Hero of Time. It carries copies of the Master Sword and the Hylian Shield and nothing else, as in the game. Everything it does that the hero doesn't (Mirror, the Answer, sinking into the floor, the roll) is a move it makes in the game, with a rule attached. Three things here are rulings and not canon, and they're marked where they come up: that it's a creature of evil, that it can't be poisoned, charmed or frightened, and that the copy keeps the hero's Fighter features.

Snapshot: the shadow of the Hero in his prime, level 20

Dark Link

Medium Construct (shadow), a creature of evil · black from the cap to the boots, red eyes, the shadow of the Master Sword and the shadow of the Hylian Shield · it doesn't speak, and neither does he · Navi: "Conquer yourself!"

AC 20 (the hero's) · **HP** 224 (the hero's maximum: two for every heart) · **Speed** 30 ft · **Initiative** +11 · **Proficiency** +6 · **Superiority dice** 6d12, DC 19

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	20 (+5)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	8 (−1)

Saves Str +8, Con +9; Indomitable ×3; advantage on Dexterity saves against anything that isn't a spell (Shadow Roll) · **Immune** to poison, and to being Poisoned, Charmed or Frightened *(ruling)* · **Skills** the hero's: Perception +15, Acrobatics +11, Stealth +11, Athletics +8 · **Languages** none

Defenses. Mirror: when a creature hits it with a melee weapon swung in one hand, it makes the same swing: it rolls a d20, and if that equals or beats the number on the attacker's die, the blades meet and the attack misses. **Sink into the Floor**: the first attack that damages it on a turn sends it under, and that creature's other attacks against it that turn have disadvantage. **Shadow Roll**: ranged weapon attacks against it have disadvantage. The shadow of the Hylian Shield keeps its Reaction: 1d10+11 off a ranged weapon attack. Nothing heals it. At 0 hit points it fades.

Attacks (four per Attack action; Action Surge twice). **The shadow of the Master Sword**: +14, 1d8+10 slashing. It's a +3 sword with Dueling behind it and no Blade of Evil's Bane in it: the copy has the edge and not the blessing. **The Answer** (Reaction, when a melee attack misses it): if the blades met, it's standing on the attacker's sword and makes one attack with advantage; if the attack simply missed, it has hopped aside, and the answer is a **Jump Slash**, +14 for 2d8+10. After it sinks, its first attack against that creature on its next turn has advantage: it came up behind.

Maneuvers the hero's nine, on the hero's dice. In practice every die is an **Ending Blow** (Trip Attack, Str DC 19, and a hit on a prone creature is a critical hit), one on each hit until the six are gone.

How it fights. The way it does in the room: it lets you swing first. A one-handed blade it matches stroke for stroke; anything that gets through, it answers by going into the floor and coming up at your back. Once it's solid it spends everything at once, both Action Surges and every die in the first two turns, because nothing it has comes back. It has no answer to a blow it can't copy: a sword in two hands, a hammer, a fist, a bullet it didn't see, fire.

What only the shadow does

Six traits, each one a thing it does in the fight. The tag under each name says what the game does; the text is the rule.

Mirror

In the game: a forward, left or right slash is met with the same slash; the blades ring and neither fighter recoils

When a creature it can see hits it with a melee weapon held in one hand, it makes the same swing. It rolls a d20. If the roll equals or beats the number showing on the attacker's d20, the blades meet and the attack misses instead; a natural 20 is met only by a 20. Nobody adds a bonus, because it has yours. It can do this against every such hit, with no action and no Reaction, and it can't do it while Prone, Incapacitated or staggered, or against an attacker it can't see. It can't mirror what it isn't holding: a weapon in two hands, a hammer, a chain, claws, a fist, a shot, a spell. About two hits in five from a swordsman as good as the hero end as a clank, and the better his roll the harder it is to match.

Stagger

In the game: after about six clashes it reels back, open. About three, if the hero is under five hearts

The sixth time the blades meet, it staggers until the end of that turn: no Mirror, no Reaction, no sinking, and attacks against it have advantage. It staggers on the third meeting instead if the creature whose blade it met is at a quarter of its hit points or fewer. The count then starts again.

The Answer

In the game: stab at it and it hops onto your blade, holds you there and cuts; jump at it and it sidesteps and jumps back at you · Reaction

When a melee attack misses it, it can use its Reaction to make one sword attack against the attacker once that creature's turn is over. If the attack missed because the blades met, it is **Standing on the Blade** and the attack has advantage. If the attack simply missed, it has side-hopped, and the attack is a **Jump Slash** that deals 2d8+10. It can't use the Answer while translucent (see the room).

Sink into the Floor

In the game: every hit knocks it back into the water; it sinks, and rises again behind the hero

The first time on each turn that an attack damages it, it sinks into its own shadow and comes up behind the attacker. That creature's other attacks against it on that turn have disadvantage, and its first attack against that creature on its next turn has advantage. It can't sink while Incapacitated or staggered, which is what the Deku Nut is for.

Shadow Roll

In the game: when an arrow, a hookshot or a bomb is in the air it rolls clear, and can't be hurt while it rolls. When the hero casts, it stands still and raises its shield, and the fire lands anyway

Ranged weapon attacks against it have disadvantage, and it has advantage on Dexterity saving throws against anything that isn't a spell, unless it's Incapacitated or can't see the attacker. Against magic it has nothing: an ordinary save.

A shadow

Rulings, not canon. The game says only that it is an enemy in a cursed temple, and that it looks like him

It's a Construct, not a Humanoid, and a creature of evil: the real Master Sword's Evil's Bane applies to it, as the real sword bites it in the game twice as deep as its copy bites the hero. It's immune to poison and can't be Poisoned, Charmed or Frightened; it doesn't eat, breathe or sleep. It can be Stunned like anything else. In the game a Deku Nut, a Hookshot or a Boomerang freezes it for four seconds and does no damage: on these sheets the Deku Nut is the same DC 18 Constitution save the hero offers everyone, and a Hookshot, Longshot or Boomerang that hits deals no damage to it and forces the same save, Stunned until the end of its next turn.

The room

Lair rules, for the fight where the game has it. **The illusion.** The room looks like open water to the horizon; it's a walled chamber, and the far door is barred while the shadow stands. Past the island the hero's reflection is gone from the water. **Waking.** It stands under the tree and wakes when a creature comes near it, targets it, or looses anything at it. **The translucent minute.** It wakes translucent and takes one minute, ten rounds, to turn solid (64 seconds by the game's counter). Until then it never attacks: no Attack action, no Answer. Mirror, sinking and the roll all work, so for a minute it is a thing you can't cut that doesn't cut back. Once solid it attacks unprompted. **Leaving.** If the hero leaves the room it's whole again when he returns, and translucent again. **The end.** At 0 it fades, the water and the horizon go with it, and the door opens. The Longshot is in the next room.

The Reflection: how to build it for any hero

Take the sheet of the creature it reflects, at that creature's current level and maximum hit points. **Keep** the body: ability scores, hit point maximum, AC, speed, saves, proficiencies, and every class feature and feat that is in the arm or the feet. Keep one weapon and one shield, the ones in its hands, with their bonuses and none of their blessings. **Strip** everything that heals (Second Wind, potions, fairies), every other item, every spell and anything that runs on a resource the shadow has no vessel for, every companion, and anything that was given to the hero by a god. **Add** the six traits above.

For the Hero of Time, **what it kept**: four attacks, Action Surge ×2, Indomitable ×3, Studied Attacks and the masteries from the Fighter; the dice and the Hidden Skills from the Battle Master; and the feats that are in the arm and not in the pack: Alert, Tough, Dueling, Shield Master, Boon of Combat Prowess. **What it didn't**: Second Wind, the bow and everything else in the pack, the Magic Meter and Nayru's Love, the bottles and the fairies, the Ocarina, the masks, Navi, the Triforce of Courage, and Evil's Bane. Level by level:

Hero's level	HP	AC	The sword	Attacks	Action Surge	Indomitable	Dice	
9	103	20	+12, 1d8+10	2	1	1	5d8, DC 17	The Water Temple, where the game puts it
11	125	20	+12, 1d8+10	3	1	1	5d10, DC 17	The hero as he leaves the Water Temple
13	147	20	+13, 1d8+10	3	1	2	5d10, DC 18	
17	191	20	+14, 1d8+10	3	2	3	6d10, DC 19	
20	224	20	+14, 1d8+10	4	2	3	6d12, DC 19	The headline block; the one on the ladder

Snapshots, with the feats checked

The room without walls

The Water Temple, Ocarina of Time: the only place it has ever stood · The hero's level 9

AC 20 · **HP** 103 · two attacks at +12 for 1d8+10 · one Action Surge, one Indomitable · five d8s, DC 17 · translucent for the first ten rounds

The feat, checked. The game's numbers: it has two points of health for every heart container the hero owns, a Master Sword slash takes two and a jump slash four, and its own sword takes half a heart from him. So it needs twice as many hits as he does, and the fight is the hero's to lose. On these sheets his Master Sword does 1d8+10 and 2d8 radiant, about 23, into 103 hit points, and the copy does about 14 into his: five hits against eight, close to the game's two to one once the Mirror has eaten its share. The game's known answers all come out of the rules without being written in. **The Deku Nut** stuns it, and a stunned shadow can't mirror or sink. **The Megaton Hammer** and **Biggoron's Sword** take two hands, so there's nothing for it to copy; in the game it raises its shield at the hammer and is hit anyway, and Biggoron's Sword does double. **Din's Fire** is a spell, so the roll doesn't help; in the game it stands in the fire with its shield up. **Arrows and bombs** are what it rolls away from, in both. And a hero who stabs or jumps at it gets the Answer, which is the part of the fight everyone remembers.

The shadow on the sand

The arena: the hero in his prime walks in, and so does this · The hero's level 20

The headline block: AC 20, 224 HP, four attacks, the six traits. It walks in solid: the arena has no room and no minute to wait

The feat, checked. Against the Hero of Time it loses every time, in three or four rounds: he has the nuts, Nayru's Love, the fairies and a sword that was made for exactly this. Across the ladder it wins about three fights in ten, fifteenth of eighteen, and who it beats follows from the game. It beats what it can copy or roll away from: Talion and his one-handed sword nine times in ten, Arthur Morgan's revolvers nine in ten, Spike and Goblin Slayer every time, and Itachi about three times in five, because there's no mind in it for a genjutsu to hold. It loses to what it can't copy: Guts and the Dragonslayer five times in six, and Jin's two-handed katana, Crane's claws and V more than nine times in ten. Musashi, whose swords it can copy, beats it nine times in ten anyway, and it all but never beats the Slayer, Anderson, Guy, Smasher, Battle Beast or Kratos. Two fighters change weapons for it: Kratos leaves the Axe for the Blades on their chains, and V takes the katana in both hands. Put back in its own room, translucent for ten rounds, it beats only the two who can't kill it in a minute, Spike and Goblin Slayer; everyone else is through its 224 hit points before it has a blade to hit them with.

Other shadows

Other games, other heroes: notes, not sheets

Several heroes have met one. The Reflection rule builds any of them from that hero's sheet; what differs is who made it and what it's for

The others. Link's Shadow (*The Adventure of Link*, 1987) is the first: the last trial of the Great Palace, stepping out of the hero's own shadow between him and the Triforce of Courage. It is the purest case of the rule, a duel with no tricks in it but his own. **Shadow Link** (*Four Swords Adventures*) is a different creature and would need a different sheet: *Hyrule Historia* says they are demons born of the Dark Mirror, there are many of them, and they do things on their own account. The four **Dark Links** of the Palace of the Four Sword (*A Link to the Past*, the Game Boy Advance version) each fight with a different one of the hero's techniques. Veran's copies of the hero (*Oracle of Ages*), the dark figures in Lanayru's vision (*Twilight Princess*), the last opponent of *Spirit Tracks*' gauntlet and the StreetPass shadows of *A Link Between Worlds* are all the same idea with less on the page. *Hyrule Warriors* and *Super Smash Bros.* are outside the canon this sheet uses, and in *Breath of the Wild* it's a suit of armor.

A DM's dial

Four knobs, the most generous first. **The level.** The game only ever shows this shadow against a hero at about the midpoint of his story. Scaling it to the hero in front of it is the health rule taken at its word; if you'd rather stat only what was on screen, it's the ninth-level block and it stays there. **The Fighter's features.** The first draft of this sheet copied the body, the sword and the shield and nothing else: no Action Surge, no dice, no Indomitable. It beat Spike and Goblin Slayer and lost to everyone else on the ladder nearly every time. Copying the hero's training along with his arm is a ruling, and it's the one that makes it a fight. **Mirror.** Limiting it to one-handed weapons is this sheet's reading of why the hammer and Biggoron's Sword are the game's easy answers. Let it mirror any sword and it gets a good deal harder for Guts and Jin. **Creature of evil.** If your table reads it as a neutral trial, the Master Sword loses 2d8 a hit against it and the hero's fight gets longer, though not much more dangerous. One more, with no canon behind it at all: the room makes a shadow of whoever walks in. Apply the Reflection to Guts.